

COLMAR FRANCE

Fiery Tarte Flambée in Alsace

Colmar's old town reflects a time when half-timbered houses were all the rage and you could never have enough gables, balconies, or spires. Delightfully Alsatian in look and attitude, the town is a little more German than French, and so is the food: pretzels, sausage, cabbage, and *tarte flambée*, a satisfyingly crispy crust anointed with a rich cream and bacon topping.



Colmar has both French and Germanic traits in its cooking, its architecture, and its festivals.

Full of Alsatian atmosphere, from its half-timbered houses to its medieval alleyways, the town is a vivid reminder not just of the proximity of the German border, but of the many disputes over its allegiance; it has been alternately part of France and Germany many times in its history. In the Middle Ages, Colmar was the region's port, and farmers were still using the canals to deliver their produce to the central covered market right up until the 1950s. The farmers are long gone, and the area – now known as Petite Venise – features tourist boats, a tootling train, and quayside cafés, but still something of the old-world charm remains, as the canals gently weave among the tall, ornately carved 16th-century buildings.

It was not until the 19th century that the Alsations invented their famous tart – *tarte flambée* – and it was more by accident than intention. The canny farm women of the Kochersberg region used to roll out their

left-over bread dough and pop it in among the wood-stoked flames to check the readiness of their oven for bread-baking. Its place in the oven flames explains its name, although some like to think it's also because the edges are always singed black, or flamed.

Pantry staples began to grace the rectangular, ultra-thin crust: a slather of homemade cream, some thinly sliced onions picked from the field, and chunks of home-cured bacon. In the fierce oven heat, it took a matter of minutes to cook – the ultimate fast food. At first the lunch of choice for just a small clutch of farmers in the Lower Rhine, it soon became emblematic of all Alsace. Towns both high and low on the Rhine now serve up “flame tart,” or *flammekueche*. There's even a *Confrérie de la Vritable Tarte Flambée d'Alsace* (Brotherhood of the Real Alsatian Flamed Tart) to ensure the quality of the crust dished up in Alsatian restaurants. They insist on a certain recipe, cooked in a wood-fired oven, but they are open to variations on ingredient ratios, and even sanction a sweet version with sliced apple. In keeping with all things Alsatian, a happy blend is finally what counts.

The Alsatian Wine Route

Colmar is the “capital of Alsatian wine” and part of the 106-mile (170-km) *Route des Vins* (Wine Route). Threading through vast vineyards dotted with cobblestone villages and castles, it's easy to follow and a great way to explore the region. The route runs from Marlenheim to Thann, along the eastern foothills of the Vosges mountains, and there are more than 40 vineyards with wines to try along the way. Around 90 percent of Alsatian wine is white – Riesling, Sylvaner, Gewürztraminer, and Pinot Gris. If you'd like to do some wine tasting but don't want to drive the wine trail, try cellars in Colmar that are open for tastings, such as **Domaine Viticole de la Ville de Colmar** (www.domaineviticolectolmar.fr), **Domaine Robert Karcher et Fils** (www.vins-karcher.com), or organic wine grower **Martin Jund** (www.vin-bio-jund.com), who also offers accommodations.



Above Dining alfresco in the Place de l'Ancienne Douane, Colmar



The Best Places to Eat Tarte Flambée

La Maison Rouge inexpensive

A Colmar gem known for its warm welcome and well-priced food, La Maison Rouge has been serving up Alsatian favorites for more than 30 years. In keeping with its name, there's a lot of red splashed around, from lamps and red-trimmed tablecloths to the blazing *rouge* walls of the cellar dining room. It's whispered, however, that the name dates back to a less cheery time, when the executioners from the guillotine stayed here and the red was a reference to the blood on their hands. There's nothing to fear these days, though, and the delicious food runs from *bibalakas* – a rib-sticking mix of *fromage blanc* (soft white cheese), chives, and garlic served with sautéed potatoes, cheese, and ham – to the house favorite of ham spit-roasted on the bone (*jambon à l'os braisé à la broche*). But locals flock here for the four kinds of *tarte flambée*, including one garnished with goat cheese and basil, and a deluxe Upper Rhine version made with Munster, a high-fat, full-cream-milk cheese.

9 rue des Ecoles, Colmar; open noon–2 PM and 6:30–10 PM Tue–Sat; www.maison-rouge.net

Also in Colmar

Aux Clefs de Colmar (+33 3 8923 9215; *inexpensive*) serves up traditional regional food, from pork knuckle baked with a Munster-cheese crust to a host of *flammekueche*, or as they're known here, “flams.” There's a basic flam of bacon, onion, and *fromage blanc*, several cheese versions (with Emmental, Munster, and goat cheese), plus one with smoked salmon and another with mushrooms.

Also in France

La Strasbourgeoise (+33 1 4205 2002; *moderate*) in Paris sits appropriately opposite the Gare de l'Est, the station for trains to and from Alsace. In place since 1950, this is a little corner of Alsace in the French capital, from the choucroute piled high with pork to the traditional *tarte flambée*, a crispy thin crust painted with cream and speckled with bacon and finely sliced onion. Wash it down with a mug of Alsatian beer or a pitcher of Riesling.

Around the World

Alsatian specialties litter the menu at Boston's **Brasserie Jo** (www.brasseriejo.com; *inexpensive*), including *tarte flambée*. They serve the classic – with fresh white cheese, bacon, and onions – plus two new versions that might earn the disdain of traditionalists but please the locals, with spinach, Gruyère cheese, and garlic chips, or blue cheese and walnut.